

Supplemental Handout - *Fiction, Myth, and Reality*

Why “ascent” looks tempting — and why Salmon rejects it

One of Salmon’s main targets is the thought that negative existentials involving fictional names can only be understood by **moving to a higher semantic level**. Both **Frege** and **Kripke** are drawn to some version of this strategy. In each case, the motivation is understandable: if “*Sherlock Holmes*” does not designate an ordinary concrete individual, then “*Sherlock Holmes does not exist*” seems hard to interpret as an ordinary subject-predicate claim. So the idea is to **translate** or **reconstruct** the sentence into something less metaphysically puzzling. Salmon’s complaint is that these maneuvers do not really solve the problem. They either **change the meaning** or **reproduce the same difficulty one level up**. (pp. 52–55, 62–65)

Comparison Table: Frege, Kripke, and Salmon

View	Why ascent/translation seems warranted	What the analysis looks like	What it is trying to preserve	How Salmon undercuts it
Frege: semantic ascent	If “ <i>Sherlock Holmes</i> ” lacks a referent, then “ <i>Sherlock Holmes does not exist</i> ” cannot straightforwardly predicate nonexistence of Holmes. So one moves from the object-language to a metalinguistic claim. (pp. 51–53)	“‘ Sherlock Holmes ’ designates nothing. ”	The truth of negative existentials, without requiring a nonexistent object to bear properties.	Salmon says this captures at most what the utterance pragmatically conveys , not its actual semantic content . It also fails the translation test : ordinary existential claims do not mean the same thing as metalinguistic claims about English expressions. (pp. 52–53)
Frege: intensional ascent	If talking about the word is too shallow, one may instead talk about the sense associated with the word. (pp. 53–54)	Roughly: the sense of “Sherlock Holmes” is not a concept of anything.	A closer fit with the logical/modal behavior of existential claims than crude semantic ascent provides.	Salmon thinks this is more sophisticated, but still not available to a Millian/direct-reference theorist . It relies on robust Fregean senses doing semantic work, and Salmon rejects that as the right diagnosis here. (pp. 54–55)

Kripke: ascent to propositions	Kripke wants to preserve the intuition that the original fictional use of the name is still, in an important sense, empty. But then “<i>Holmes does not exist</i>” cannot straightforwardly express an ordinary proposition, so it is reconstrued in terms of propositions and truth. (pp. 62–63)	“There is no true proposition that Holmes exists.” In the strongest case: perhaps there is no such proposition at all.	The truth of negative existentials, while preserving the idea that the original fictional name does not designate an ordinary individual.	Salmon says this simply repeats the problem upstairs. If <i>Holmes</i> is problematic in “<i>Holmes exists</i>,” then it is equally problematic in “<i>the proposition that Holmes exists</i>.” The analysis generates a regress, not a solution. (pp. 63–64)
Kripke: Holmes₁ / Holmes₂ ambiguity	Kripke distinguishes the fictional “person” use from the metafictional artifact use: the former is empty, the latter names the fictional character. (pp. 58–61)	Holmes₁ = the pretend detective, genuinely empty; Holmes₂ = the actual fictional character, an abstract artifact.	Both our intuition that “the detective does not exist” and our ability to talk truly about Sherlock Holmes as a fictional character.	Salmon thinks this is unnecessarily baroque. There is no good reason to posit a prior, genuinely empty use and then a second parasitic one. The simpler view is that the genuine use is just the use that names the fictional character. (pp. 66–70, 74–75)

The core dialectic

Why Frege is tempted by ascent

Frege's pressure comes from his semantics of reference. If a proper name fails to designate, then an ordinary predicative reading of a sentence like "*Sherlock Holmes exists*" or "*Sherlock Holmes does not exist*" looks blocked. That makes it natural to reinterpret the sentence as really saying something about the **name** or its **sense**, rather than about Holmes himself. (pp. 51–54)

Why Kripke is tempted by ascent

Kripke's pressure is slightly different. He wants to distinguish the real fictional character from the merely pretended detective. But if the original fictional use of the name is genuinely empty, then a negative existential involving that use cannot simply express a singular proposition. So Kripke shifts to talk of **truth**, **propositions**, and the absence of a true proposition of the relevant form. (pp. 62–63)

Why Salmon thinks both strategies fail

Salmon's recurring point is that **an empty name does not become less problematic merely by being embedded in a more elaborate construction**. If "*Holmes*" is troublesome in:

- "*Holmes does not exist*,"

it is still troublesome in:

- "*'Holmes' designates nothing*,"
- "*the sense of 'Holmes' is not a concept of anything*,"
- "*there is no true proposition that Holmes exists*."

So ascent does not eliminate the problem. It only **places it up a level**. (pp. 52–55, 63–65)

Salmon's alternative

Salmon's own proposal is that names from fiction and myth are, in their fundamental literal use, **names for abstract artifacts**. Thus:

- "**Sherlock Holmes**" names a fictional character created by Conan Doyle.

- “**Vulcan**” names a mythical object generated by a false theory.
(pp. 68–77)

That lets Salmon say:

- object-fictional sentences can express propositions **about** fictional characters;
- such propositions are often **literally false** but **true according to the fiction**;
- metafictional discourse becomes intelligible without positing a mysterious, prior, empty use.
(pp. 70–75)

When we say “*Sherlock Holmes does not really exist*,” Salmon thinks we often shift into a **descriptive** or **Pickwickian** use: we mean that there is no **Holmes-like person** in reality, not that there is no fictional character at all. (pp. 73–75)